

TELE SALES ESSENTIALS

Tele Sales Essentials — Day 2: Opening the Call and Reading the First Seconds

Study guide · Self-study

Day 2: Opening the Call and Reading the First Seconds

How to Use This Guide

This guide covers Day 2 of Tele Sales Essentials. It is self-study. You work alone, at your own pace, with a phone and, for some exercises, a friend on the other end of the line.

Day 1 showed you how tele sales works and how to prepare a session. Today you learn the first thirty seconds, the part of the call that decides whether the rest of it happens.

Read a section, then stop and practice it before you move on. Say the lines out loud. An opener only works when it sounds like you, not like a page you are reading.

You do not need a tele sales job to do this. Every exercise has a version for someone still practicing alone: role-play with a friend, record yourself, use the fictional people in this guide. If you have a job and use real calls, never write down a real name, number or personal detail.

One more thing before you start. Law and company policy set who you may call, when you may call, how you handle a do-not-call request and whether you must give a recording notice. Follow both. A do-not-call request is logged straight away, every time. Your voice on a good call never breaks those rules.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know the four steps of the First-Contact Standard and how to adapt them for an inbound sales call.

Attitude: You will see the first seconds of a call as something you earn, not something you are owed. Calm and interest beat fast and loud.

Skill: You will be able to open an outbound call and answer an inbound one with a short, clear opening, a pace that sounds credible, and one easy question at the end.

Upskill: You will be able to ask a gatekeeper for help finding the right person, and to tell a brush-off from a real no inside the first minute.

The First Seconds Decide the Call

Think about the last sales call you received. Before the other person finished their first sentence, you had already answered a silent question: is this safe? Then another: is it about me? Then a third: do I want to keep listening?

Your client does the same. Psychologists describe two ways of thinking (Kahneman, 2011). In fast thinking, people make quick, automatic judgments, including judgments about strangers on a phone. Slow, careful thinking only switches on when something seems worth the effort. A cold call rarely earns that effort at the start. So your opening is judged by fast thinking, and fast thinking reacts to tone, calmness and whether the call is clearly about the person listening.

Pressure makes this harder. People push back when they feel their choice is being taken away (Brehm, 1966). That is why an opener that corners someone ("this will only take a minute") so often produces a fast no. An opener that gives them room to say no often produces a conversation instead.

The First-Contact Standard (MEDJAY adaptation, based on Kahneman, Brehm and Guyer et al.) is a four-behavior structure for every first contact, used in this order: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It is a structure, not a script, and it is for opening calls. Its goal is an opening the other person chooses to continue.

Here is what each step does.

Low Threat: Open calmly and unhurried. Say who you are and who you represent, at a natural pace. This answers the first silent question: is this safe? A rushed start tells the listener you expect to be rejected, and they hear it.

Autonomy: Give the person a clear, easy way to decline or say not now. Feeling free to leave is what makes it safe to stay. This sounds strange until you try it. When you say "if now is not a good time, just tell me," most people relax, because you have not trapped them.

Relevance: Give one true reason this call is about them, not you. This answers: is this relevant? One reason. Not a list of benefits and not your company history. Day 1 gave you the habit of one true reason per contact. This is where it enters the call.

Curiosity: Ask one easy, open question that invites them to talk. This answers: do I want to continue?, by giving them something easy to say. An open question is one that cannot be answered with yes or no. Keep it small, so answering costs them almost nothing.

The order matters. Safety first, then freedom, then relevance, then curiosity. Skip a step and the next one sounds like a pitch.

> **NOTES**
>
> When you practice, listen back for the moment your pace speeds up. That is usually where you stopped trusting the structure.

The Outbound Opener in Practice

Here is the structure with words in it. Read it once, then make it yours.

"Hello, this is (your name) from (your company). I know I am calling out of the blue, so if now is a bad time just say so and I will not keep you. I am calling because (one true reason that fits this person). Is that something you deal with at the moment?"

Notice what is not there. No "how are you today," a question that means nothing. No "I will be quick," which tells the listener the call is about your need to get through it. No price, no feature list. Just safety, freedom, one reason and one small question.

The one true reason must be something the person would recognize. If they asked for information, say so. If they are a past customer, say so. If they are on an approved list because of a real offer that fits their situation, name that situation in plain words.

Practice example: A fictional rep called Dana works for a made-up internet provider and calls a fictional small business owner, a bakery on an approved list, because a new plan in her area is faster at the same price. Her opener: "Hello, this is Dana from Northline Internet. I know this is an unexpected call, so if now is a bad time, just tell me. I am calling because the plan this bakery is on

was replaced last month, and in your area the new one is faster at the same price. Is the internet speed something you notice during a busy morning?" The reason is checkable, it is about the bakery, and the question is easy to answer.

Notice the last line. It is not "would you like to hear more," which is a yes or no question that invites a no. It is an open question about their day. That is what earns the next thirty seconds.

Answering an Inbound Sales Call

On an inbound call, the caller has already done the hard part. They rang you. Your job is not to earn their attention with a reason. Your job is to show, fast, that you understood why they called.

Adapt the First-Contact Standard like this. Low Threat still matters: answer with a calm, clear greeting and your name, because a rushed or flat answer makes people wonder if they reached the right place. Autonomy still matters: the caller may need to gather information before deciding anything, so let them know they can. Relevance changes. Instead of giving a reason, show you heard their reason, in their words. Curiosity stays: one small open question to find out what they need.

Practice example: A fictional caller rings a made-up insurance line and says she wants to know about cover for a small delivery business. The rep, Sam, answers: "Good morning, Sam speaking, you have reached the business insurance line. Thanks for calling. I want to make sure I help with exactly what you need, so tell me a little about the business and what you are covering at the moment. Take your time, there is no rush." Sam has not asked her name twice, has not read a script about other products, and has invited her to talk. Her reason is now the center of the call.

The common mistake on inbound calls is to start selling before you understand. The caller tells you they want one thing, and the rep hears an opening for three other products. Hold back. Understand first, recommend later. You will practice recommending on Day 3.

Your Voice Is Half the Message

On the phone, your client cannot see your face. They read your voice instead. Research on vocal confidence (Guyer et al., 2019) suggests people judge a speaker as more credible when the delivery is calm and steady rather than fast and hurried. Your listener is doing that judging without noticing.

Four things to work on.

Pace. A slightly slower delivery than your normal speaking speed gives the listener time to catch your name and your reason. Fast talking, especially at the start, sounds like nerves, and nerves sound like someone who expects to be hung up on.

Tone. Speak as if to a person across a table, not to a room. Smiling is not visible, but it changes your tone, and people hear the difference. You do not need to perform cheerfulness. You need to sound like a person.

Short sentences. One idea per sentence. "I know this is an unexpected call. If now is a bad time, just tell me." Two short sentences are easier to follow than one long one, and they give you natural places to pause.

Pauses. A short pause after your question is not dead air. It is space for the other person, whose thinking may be slower than yours because the call is new to them. If you rush to fill every pause, you will answer your own question and lose the answer.

Before you dial, do the breathing routine from Day 1. The Physiological Sigh: two inhales through the nose, the second one short, then a long, slow exhale through the mouth. A few rounds settle your body, and your voice follows your body. A calm voice is not a trick. It is a settled one.

A Brush-Off Is Not a No

"A bit busy right now." "Just send me something." "I am about to go into a meeting."

New reps hear these and treat them as rejections. Mostly they are not. They are fast, low-effort reactions to an unexpected call, given before the person has judged anything. The person is protecting their time, not refusing your offer, because they have not yet heard what the offer is.

A real no sounds different. It is a decision. "I am not interested, and I do not want to be called again." "We already have a provider and we are not changing." When you hear a clear no, you accept it, you thank them, and you handle any do-not-call request at once, following the rules from Day 1.

Between the two, your job is to give the brush-off somewhere to go without pressure. Try one calm line, then step back. "Of course, it sounds like a full morning. I only need thirty seconds to tell you why I called. If it is not useful, say so and I will let you go. The reason I rang is (one true reason). Does that land as useful or not?"

Then listen. If they say it is useful, you have your conversation. If they say no, you have an honest close, and you respect it. What you never do is repeat the same push three times. That turns a brush-off into a real no, and you caused it.

> **NOTES**
>
> Watch for this trap: the pause after your question feels much longer to you than to the person listening. Count slowly to three before you fill it.

Getting Past a Gatekeeper by Asking for Help

In B2B calls, the person who answers is often not the decision maker. They are an assistant, a receptionist, an office manager. Their job is to protect the time of the people they work for.

The rookie move is to treat the gatekeeper as a wall and push through: "I need to speak to the person in charge of purchasing." Push, and you give them a reason to defend the wall, because their job is being tested.

The better move is to ask for help, and to do it with a small, honest, specific request. People like to help, and a request that respects their role is hard to refuse. Stay honest about what you want: do not pretend to be a colleague, a courier or a long-lost contact. Never give a false name or a fake reason. A lie found out ends the account.

Practice example: A fictional rep called Rui calls a made-up logistics company to book a meeting about a service that reduces delivery paperwork. The office manager answers. "Hello, this is Rui from Farfield. I want to reach the person who deals with delivery paperwork. I do not want to guess the name and get it wrong, so I am asking for help. What would be the best way to reach the right person?" She has not pushed, she has not asked to be put through blind, and she has made her reason clear. Most people answer a question like that.

Two lines to have ready. If the gatekeeper asks what it is about: "Happy to say. It is about (the topic, in one short phrase). Who would be the right person for that?" If they say the person is not available: "Thanks for checking. What is the best way to reach them, a call at a better time or a short note?" You are gathering a route in, not demanding a door.

Apply It in Your Role

If you already work in tele sales, take today's material onto your next calls. Write your outbound opener in full and say it out loud until it sounds natural, not read. Record yourself on two calls with a colleague posing as a client, and listen for your pace in the first ten seconds. Keep one line of notes after each real call about how the opening landed. Never write a real client's name, number or personal detail.

If you do not have a tele sales job yet, you have plenty to practice. Call a friend, explain the exercise, and ask them to play a busy small business owner. Use the fictional bakery and logistics examples in this guide as your starting scripts, then swap in a made-up company of your own. If no one is free, record your opener on your phone and listen back the way a client would. And the easiest practice of all: the next time a stranger calls you with an offer, listen to their first sentence and judge it honestly. What made you want to hear more? What made you want to hang up?

Your challenge for today, before Day 3: write your own outbound opener in the four steps. Say who you are. Give a way to decline. Give one true reason. End with one open question.

Write it here. Your name: ____

Your company: ____

Your low-threat opening line: ____

Your autonomy line (the way to decline): ____

Your one true reason: ____

Your curiosity question: ____

Then record it once. Keep it under twenty seconds. Then run the gatekeeper role-play with a friend: they play an office manager, you ask for help finding the right person. Do it twice, once where they say the person is out, once where they put you through.

What Would You Say?

Write your response to each situation before you turn to the model answers at the end.

1. A man answers your outbound call with a flat "I am busy." What do you say next?

2. A woman rings in about mobile plans. What are your first two sentences?

3. An assistant asks why you are calling before she will put you through to her manager.

4. A small business owner says "Just send me an email" in the first ten seconds.

5. You have a soft, quiet voice and you are worried you sound unsure on calls. What do you work on?

Key Takeaways

- The first seconds of a call are decided by fast, automatic judgment, so calmness and relevance matter more than a clever script.
- The First-Contact Standard orders every opening: Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity. It is a structure, not a script.
- On inbound calls, keep the safety and freedom, and make Relevance show you heard the caller's reason in their words.
- A calm, slightly slower voice with short sentences sounds more credible than a fast one. Settle your body with the Physiological Sigh before you dial.
- A brush-off protects time; a real no is a decision. Give the brush-off one calm line, then respect the answer and log any do-not-call request.
- Ask a gatekeeper for help reaching the right person. Stay honest about why you are calling.
- End every opening with one small, open question, and let the answer come.

Quiz

Choose the best answer for each question. Write your answers down before you check the notes.

1. Which order does the First-Contact Standard use?

A. Relevance, Low Threat, Curiosity, Autonomy
B. Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity
C. Curiosity, Relevance, Autonomy, Low Threat
D. Autonomy, Curiosity, Low Threat, Relevance

2. On an inbound sales call, what does Relevance mean?

A. Reading the current promotion to the caller
B. Asking the caller for their name and address first
C. Showing you understood the caller's reason, in their words
D. Telling the caller who you are

3. Why does a calm, slightly slower pace help in the first seconds?

A. It sounds more credible and gives the listener time to catch your name and reason
B. It lets you fit more information into the call
C. It makes the call shorter

D. It hides the fact that you are calling from a list

4. A client says "I am busy right now." What is the best reading?

   A. A firm no that you should log at once

   B. A request to call back at the same time tomorrow without asking

   C. A clear sign the offer is wrong for them

   D. A fast reaction to an unexpected call, with the offer not yet heard

5. What is the best way to get past a gatekeeper?

   A. Refuse to explain and ask to be put through immediately

   B. Give a false reason to sound more important

   C. Ask honestly for help reaching the right person, and say what the call is about

   D. Call back every hour until you get a different person

Upskill Challenge

This is your on-the-job challenge, done at home before Day 3.

Record a twenty-second outbound opener using your own name and a fictional company. Use all four steps. Send it to a friend and ask one question only: "Did you want to keep listening after my first sentence?" Write down their answer.

Then run the gatekeeper role-play twice with a friend, as in the challenge above. After each round, ask your friend what made it easy or hard to help you. Write one sentence on what you will change.

Then do this reflection. Write it down.

What did I feel in my body before the opener: ____

What changed in my voice when I rushed: ____

What one line will I practice out loud before Day 3: ____

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. The principle matters more than the exact words, and your words should sound like you.

1. "I can hear you are busy, so I will keep it to this. I called because (one true reason). If it is not useful, tell me and I will let you go. Does that sound useful or not?" Why it works: it names the busyness without apologizing, gives one true reason, and lets the person close the call honestly, which is why they often do not.

2. "Good morning, (your name) speaking, you have reached the mobile plans line. Thanks for calling. Tell me a little about what you are looking for and what you use at the moment, and we will find out if it fits. Take your time." Why it works: it is a calm greeting with a name, it shows the caller reached the right place, and it hands the conversation to their reason instead of a product list.

3. "Happy to say. It is about (the topic in one short phrase). I am asking for help so I reach the right person and do not waste anyone's time. What would be the best way to reach them?" Why it works: it is honest, short and specific, and it asks the assistant to help in a way that fits her role.

4. "Of course, I can send a short note. So it is about the right thing, tell me one line about (the topic) at the moment, and I will make the note worth reading." Why it works: it agrees without arguing, and it keeps a small, easy open question in the call. If the person still wants only the email, you send it and log it as a follow-up with a date.

5. Focus on the long, slow exhale before each call, and lower your pace slightly rather than raising your volume. Short sentences and a real pause after your question carry more confidence than loudness. Record once a day and compare. Why it works: credibility is judged from pace and steadiness, and both come from a settled body.

Quiz answers:

1. B. The four steps run Low Threat, Autonomy, Relevance, Curiosity, because safety comes before relevance and freedom before curiosity.

2. C. The caller already has a reason, so Relevance means hearing that reason back in their words, not reading an offer to them.

3. A. People judge credibility from voice, and a steadier pace gives the listener time to catch your name and your one true reason.

4. D. A brush-off is a low-effort reaction to an unexpected call, given before the person has judged the offer, so it is not yet a no.

5. C. Asking for help with an honest topic is hard to refuse and respects the gatekeeper's role; pushing, lying or calling repeatedly does not.

> **NOTES**
>
> If your opener goes past thirty seconds, cut a sentence before you cut the reason.

References

Guyer, J. J., Fabrigar, L. R., & Vaughan-Johnston, T. I. (2019). Speech rate, intonation, and pitch: Investigating the bias and cue effects of vocal confidence on persuasion. Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin, 45(3), 389–405.

Brehm, J. W. (1966). A Theory of Psychological Reactance. Academic Press.

Kahneman, D. (2011). Thinking, Fast and Slow. Farrar, Straus and Giroux.